

UK Construction SMEs: AI Benefits and System Fit, 2026

A workflow-level secondary-evidence review



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EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Controlled document work is the strongest near-term fit

The evidence supports a plausible workflow case for requirement extraction, evidence retrieval and first-draft control. It does not establish UK construction-SME ROI or autonomous construction.

30% document management Perceived high significance; global RICS survey	96.25% prototype F1 Requirement extraction; two-case research setting	60 to 15 reported minutes Large-company legal review; self-reported
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Keep evidence types separate

- Industry perception identifies where professionals expect significance.
- Prototype performance measures a narrow technical task.
- A company case can illustrate implementation but does not create a sector benchmark.
- None of these measures tender quality, win rate, margin, safety or compliance.

01 EVIDENCE LADDER

Claim strength moves with evidence strength

Evidence	Observed signal	Permitted interpretation
RICS professional survey	36% scheduling/progress, 30% document management, 29% risk	Perceived opportunity in a global, non-SME-only sample
Bid research prototype	96.25% average F1 reported for extraction	Narrow technical performance in the reported test
ConstructionCo case	Legal review reportedly reduced from about 60 to 15 minutes	Self-reported departmental transfer case in a large employer
Cast Consultancy	Qualitative confidence and capability improvements	Named SME implementation journey, not performance evaluation
DSIT skills synthesis	Tender preparation and programme coordination priorities	Official implementation and training context

The signals are not pooled, averaged or converted into a construction-SME effect size.

02 SYSTEM FIT

Set autonomy by consequence and verifiability

Position	Candidate workflow	Minimum control
Controlled deployment	Tender extraction, document classification, source-backed response skeletons	Approved sources, citations, version control and named reviewer
Conditional deployment	Scheduling support, risk prompts, contract review and coordination	Specialist review, tested integration, escalation and audit trail
Do not delegate autonomously	Safety decisions, regulatory conclusions, final pricing, programmes and commitments	Professional accountability and final judgement remain human

Why tender support

The workflow is document-heavy, reversible and testable. A requirement can be compared with its source clause, candidate evidence can be accepted or rejected, and unsupported content can remain visibly incomplete.

Where the system stops

The workflow cannot determine buildability, price the job, approve a programme, produce a final method statement or make safety and regulatory decisions.

03 MEASURE TOTAL WORKFLOW PERFORMANCE

Draft speed alone is not a benefit

Outcome family	Measures
Time	Preparation, review, correction, rework and approval hours
Coverage	Mandatory requirements found, missed and wrongly classified
Evidence	Relevant approved sources found, unsupported statements and citation defects
Quality	Material omissions, contradictions, false confidence and final corrections
Control	Incidents, escalations, overrides, rollback and retained audit trail
Economics	Licences, setup, integration, training, assurance and opportunity cost

Proceed only if quality and control remain acceptable after review and correction effort is included.

A valid stop decision

If documents are inconsistent, evidence ownership is weak, reviewers cannot explain the output or the benefit disappears after assurance, holding or stopping is a successful control outcome.

04 SOURCES AND VERDICT

A bounded benefits conclusion

1. RICS - Artificial intelligence in construction report 2025

<https://www.rics.org/news-insights/artificial-intelligence-in-construction-report>

2. DSIT - Construction AI upskilling evidence

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/skills-for-ai-what-works-for-ai-upskilling-in-the-uk/research-evidence-analysis-and-methodology-what-works-for-ai-upskilling-in-the-uk>

3. Generative AI model for construction bid preparation

<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/15623599.2026.2629023>

4. CIPD/IFOW - ConstructionCo AI journey

<https://www.cipd.org/uk/knowledge/case-studies/construction-company-ai/>

5. DSIT - Cast Consultancy supporting case

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a26e9cc2cdcfd7436ac0e6/supporting_case_studies.pdf

6. RICS - Responsible use of AI standard

<https://www.rics.org/profession-standards/rics-standards-and-guidance/conduct-competence/responsible-use-of-ai>

Verdict

A controlled tender-document workflow is a credible pilot candidate. Published evidence does not establish causal UK construction-SME productivity, profit, safety or compliance improvement.

Not construction, legal, safety, regulatory, procurement or investment advice.